# Ohio Becomes a Midterm Battleground Again

From: PBS NewsHour Mined: 2026-10-20 5 min read

In recent presidential elections, Ohio has voted reliably Republican. But in this year's midterm elections, the state is once again a major **battleground**, where either party could win.

The Cook Political Report, a group that studies elections, rates both the race for Ohio governor and the race for a U.S. Senate seat as **toss-ups**. That means each one is too close to call. Several races for the U.S. House are also **competitive**. Election Day is about two weeks away.

PBS NewsHour reporter Liz Landers visited Ohio to learn how national issues are shaping voters' choices. One big concern is **affordability**, or whether people can pay for everyday things.

In Youngstown, a city built on the steel industry, old factories still stand along the Mahoning River. Many jobs left decades ago. This summer, a local bakery closed after 120 years, and a nearby call center is also closing.

Ten years ago, Donald Trump won over many **working-class** Ohio voters by promising to bring jobs back. Now Republicans are in charge in Washington and in Ohio's capital, Columbus. Chris Anderson, who leads the local Democratic Party, said Republicans promised to tackle **inflation** but have not made people's lives better.

In the Senate race, Democrat Sherrod Brown is trying to win back a seat. He won three Senate races in Ohio before losing two years ago. He argues that Republicans made life more expensive. His opponent, Jon Husted, has said in an ad that 32 years in Washington is enough for Brown.

Gas prices have risen because of the war with Iran. Last month, Husted broke with President Trump and said the war needs to end so prices can come down. At a recent Trump rally, some supporters said they are willing to wait.

## Word Treasure

**battleground** -- A state where the election is close, so both parties work hard to win it.

**toss-ups** -- Races so close that experts cannot say who is likely to win.

**affordability** -- Whether people have enough money to pay for the things they need.

**working-class** -- Describes people who often earn wages in jobs like factory, building or service work.

**inflation** -- A general rise in prices over time, so money buys less than before.

**competitive** -- Close enough that more than one side has a real chance to win.

## Background you need

Midterm elections happen partway through a president's term, when voters choose members of Congress and many state leaders such as governors.

The U.S. Senate helps make the nation's laws, so a few close Senate races can decide which party controls it.

Some states usually lean toward one party, while battleground states are close enough that candidates spend a lot of time and money trying to win them.

Voters often judge the party in power by how everyday life feels, including the cost of food, gas and housing.

## Break it down

**LEAD:** Ohio, usually Republican in presidential races, is a midterm battleground again
**KEY EVENT:** Governor and U.S. Senate races rated toss-ups
+- WHO: Democrat Sherrod Brown vs. Jon Husted in the Senate race
+- WHERE: Ohio, including the former steel city of Youngstown
+- WHEN: About two weeks before Election Day
**EVIDENCE:** Lost jobs, a 120-year-old bakery closing, worries about affordability and gas prices
**OPEN QUESTION:** Will voters' concerns about costs change which party wins Ohio?

## Why it matters

Close races in states like Ohio could decide which party controls the U.S. Senate, which shapes the laws that affect families across the country.

## Test what you remember

**1. Why is Ohio called a battleground in this year's midterms?**

- (A) Because it has the most voters in the country
- (B) Because either party could win its big races
- (C) Because it always votes for Democrats
- (D) Because no elections are being held there

**2. How does The Cook Political Report rate the Ohio governor and Senate races?**

- (A) Canceled
- (B) Toss-ups
- (C) Safe for Democrats
- (D) Safe for Republicans

**3. What closed in Youngstown this summer after 120 years?**

- (A) A bridge
- (B) A steel mill
- (C) A local bakery
- (D) A school

**4. What is Sherrod Brown's main argument against Republicans?**

- (A) They raised the voting age
- (B) They built too many factories
- (C) They made life more expensive
- (D) They closed the Mahoning River

**5. What did Jon Husted say last month about the war with Iran?**

- (A) It will lower gas prices
- (B) It needs to end so prices can come down
- (C) It has no effect on Ohio
- (D) It should continue for years

**6. About how long until Election Day, according to the article?**

- (A) Two weeks
- (B) One year
- (C) Two days
- (D) Six months

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: A

## Questions to think about

1. Ohio Democrats (Chris Anderson): Republicans promised to tackle inflation but have not made people's lives better.
2. Sherrod Brown: Republicans have made life more expensive for Ohioans.
3. Jon Husted's ad: Thirty-two years in Washington is enough for Brown.
4. Some Trump supporters: They are willing to wait for prices to come down.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):